PROPOSAL · 13 OCTOBER 2026 · SOHO SQUARE GARDENS, W1D 3QH

A perfume museum beneath Soho Square

4 design variants for the 1928 transformer chamber

Below the lawn there is a 300 m^2 machine hall: a 1928 DC converter substation that became a Blitz shelter, sealed since about 2015. This proposal turns it into a small, hosted perfume museum with a London flagship for Tiziana Terenzi. It covers four ways to design it, with floor plans, and the moves that would make it one of the most talked-about rooms in London.



SOHO SQUARE GARDENS · 1132

FLOOR

297 m²

3,200 sq ft, 2015 particulars

PLAN

30 × 10 m

estimate, east–west

DEPTH 3.5–4.5 m below the lawn, estimate	BUILT 1928 substation, WWII shelter
STAIRS 2 west hatch + Grade II hut	VISITORS 60–70 at once, both stairs rebuilt

WHERE THINGS STAND

Westminster has the asset, no plan for it, and is listening

- **What it is.** Westminster's Corporate Landlord team confirmed on 12/10/2026 that the space is a **former electricity transformer chamber**, separate from the real WWII shelters that also lie under the square. The photos agree: steel I-beams, machine plinths, cable pits and a hoist beam. It is **not marketed, not under offer, and its future use is "under review"**.
- **Who decides.** Cllr Robert Rigby (parks) took the lead on 27/09. All letters now go to **CorporateLandlord.Property@westminster.gov.uk** only. The FOI answer is due by **26/10**.
- **Who owns the ground.** The garden is registered freehold land, most likely Westminster's or a charity Westminster runs. Tim Lord (Soho Society) points to the **trustees of the frontages**, chaired by Revd Adam Scott. UK Power Networks once wanted an option on the chamber, and that may still matter.
- **Why a museum.** In the 2015 sale, every bidder that wanted a bar, gym or restaurant failed. A **booking-only, hosted museum** is the one public use the space can lawfully hold. It gives Westminster the public-benefit evidence it needs for a below-market lease. The Soho Society has already floated a "gallery or museum", and the **Museum of Soho** (Tony Shrimplin) is the natural partner.
- **A change of position.** Your 26/09 letter offered "custodianship only, no public-facing use". A museum is a second option to put to them, not a correction of the first.

What all four variants share

- **Arrival** through the existing west hatch, rebuilt within its footprint. **Exit** through the Grade II hut, rebuilt as a protected stair with a platform lift for step-free access. Two stairs lift the cap to 60–70 visitors at once.
- **Timed, hosted groups** of 12–20 people. No queue in the garden and no signage on the lawn. Tickets carry a meeting time at the hatch.
- **Zoned air.** Every scent room gets its own extract. Alcohol stock stays in one fire-separated store under DSEAR rules.
- **Tiziana Terenzi** runs the boutique and the blending table. It would be their first London flagship.
- **Public toilet at hatch level.** Locals asked for one (Tim Lord), and it is cheap goodwill.



The long run of the hall, seen from the hut stair.



Machine pits and plinths from the 1928 converter plant.



The Grade II hut. Its south quarter holds the second stair.

DEEP BRAINSTORM · 12 MODELS + 4 DESIGN STUDIOS

The best ideas from the brainstorm

Twelve models answered the brief (two others failed or timed out). Nearly all landed on the same move independently: don't put a perfume shop in a bunker, build a machine that turns the substation's story, electricity, into scent, keeping the industrial fabric as the exhibit. Most treated the single stair and perfume's fire load as the real constraint, not the storytelling.

Ideas most models converged on

- **The Converter.** The museum as a machine turning raw material into scent, mirroring the hall's job as a DC converter. (opus, fable, sonnet, astra, gemini-flash, grok, +4 more)
- **Shelter blackout night.** A room on the real ~200-person WWII shelter history, ending in one shared scent in the dark. (opus, gemini-flash, grok, kimi, glm, +3 more)
- **Cable pits as scent wells.** Glaze or grille the sunken trenches, lit from below; the floor becomes the dispensing architecture. (all 12)

- **The chain-hoist beam as a moving device.** A trolley or bell jar travels the beam, carrying scent or light down the hall. (opus, fable, sonnet, gemini-flash, deepseek, +3 more)
- **Porcelain cleats as a scent library.** Surviving cleats become sniff ports or a raw-materials wall, reversibly fitted. (opus, fable, gemini-flash, grok, deepseek, kimi, glm)
- **No signage, booking-only arrival through the hatch.** A host meets small groups at the hut, kept a threshold, not a shop. (all 12)
- **Boutique last, plus a keyholder membership.** The shop ends the visit, editorially independent, backed by a token membership. (opus, fable, sonnet, astra, grok, +4 more)

The surprising ones worth stealing

- **Nocturne** — no daytime hours at all, open only after dark, so the garden's day users never collide with it. (fable)
- **Nose Only** — a no-object, blackout format that turns the uneven floor and low ceiling into an asset for blind visitors. (sonnet)
- **Nose Court** — a blind taste-test with a public verdict board that might show a favourite wasn't Terenzi, and it lets that stand. (astra)
- **Soho After Close** — the same rooms run twice daily: a chaste afternoon route and a harder-reset evening membership route. (grok)
- **Olfactory Darkroom** — a scent "develops" a hidden image on a card under UV light, like photo chemistry. (deepseek)
- **London Batch** — a working micro-perfumery: visitors vote on a variable, smell a batch mid-maceration; the shop sells what was just made. (kimi)
- **Museum of Air** — bottled "airs" (1928 ozone, 1940 shelter, 1968 wax, today's lawn) played like chords on a smell organ. (glm)
- **Scent Time Capsule** — guests seal a blend and mail it to themselves on its 1st, 5th or 10th anniversary. (minimax)
- **The Arc Strike** — a brief, enclosed electric arc timed with an ozone smell and a flash: one unmissable photo moment. (nemotron)

Making it super cool: the device kit

DEVICE	WHAT IT DOES	WHERE	COST (EST.)
Dry/cold scent ports	Single notes on demand, no alcohol aerosol	Cleats, plinths, pits	£300–800/port
Glazed pit scent wells	Floor becomes a lit dispensing surface	Sunken trenches	£15k–30k
Runway-beam trolley	Travelling scent/light pulse down the hall	Hoist beam	£10k–20k
Cleat sniff ports	Reversible cartridges, no drilling	Walls	£400/port
Zoned negative-pressure HVAC	Stops scent bleed; purges between groups	All zones	£150k–300k
Bone-conduction audio	Narration/bass, zero spill outside	Headsets, benches	£50–150/unit
NFC scent passport	Logs scents, drives boutique recs	At the hatch	£10–15/unit
Keyholder token + lockers	Membership + collector storage	Vault	£1k–2k/locker
Lantern admission	Replaces ceiling light, counts heads	Hatch	£40–80/each
After-hours "Dark Tasting"	Lights-off, hosted session	Evenings	£150–250/ticket

Above ground, without breaking the garden rules

- No new structures, no signage, no visible queue: a booked slot and a host meeting guests at the hut or railings; a token or lantern is the only ticket.
- The west hatch is the real entrance; the hut's ship's ladder stays emergency/exit-only unless rebuilt to public standard.
- Don't scent the garden — several models flag nuisance risk. Better to bring its own smell (grass, rain, plane trees) in as a station than push scent out.
- Any surface gesture stays passive and reversible (a glow inside the hut at dusk) and still needs listed-building consent.

The money idea others would miss

- **Rent the controlled-scent environment itself.** Four models converged independently: sell the bunker's engineered clean air and privacy to brands, as a sensory-testing studio or nose-training, on hours the public isn't in.
- **Scent storage for collectors.** Several models proposed paid, climate-stable vault lockers for collectors' bottles or "memory scents" — turning the least visitor-friendly corner into recurring income.

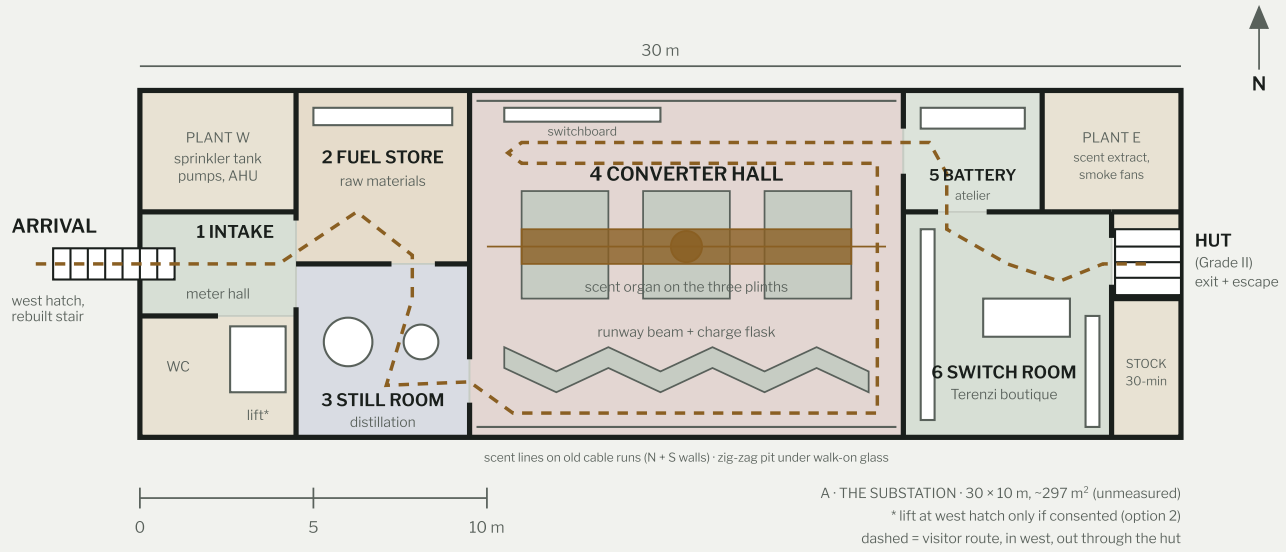
The biggest risk, and the fix

- **Risk:** in a sealed ~300 m^2 bunker with one practical stair, low ceilings and no windows, scent cross-contamination, fire load and access limits can cap the business well below any concept's promise — nearly every model names this as the single biggest threat.
- **Fix:** spend first on zoned negative-pressure HVAC with scrubbing and a purge cycle between groups, ban open alcohol spraying for dry diffusion, and size ticket economics to small hosted groups under the stair cap — bring in a fire engineer before the layout is fixed.

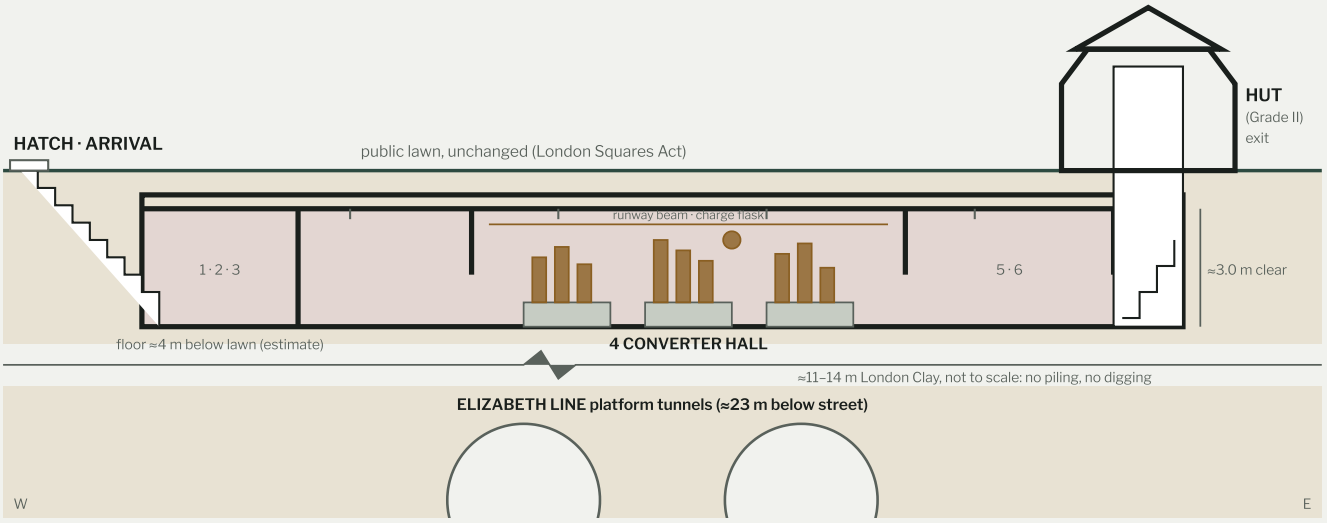
Discarded as unverified: invented 18th-century Soho trades, exact descent temperature drops, a claimed hut chimney, HMRC bonded-warehouse status, and any claim the Elizabeth line's vibration is actually perceptible on site.

A The Substation

In 1928 this room turned the city's current into power for Soho. Now it turns raw materials into scent, and you throw the switch.



Floor plan, 1:200 at 20 px/m. 30 × 10 m hall, about 297 m². West stair = arrival, hut stair = second exit.



Long section, west to east. Depths are estimates until measured.

The idea

The space under the western lawn was most likely never dug as a shelter. It is the Charing Cross Electricity Supply Co.'s 1928 DC converter hall (1,500 kW), and its plinths, pits, cable runs, porcelain cleats and chain-hoist beam are still there. This variant stops apologising for the machine hall and restores it as an industrial cathedral. Perfume is told as energy: **raw materials (fuel) → distillation**

(generation) → accord (conversion) → charge (the bottle you carry out). The three old machine plinths carry a new instrument, the Converter, a brass-and-porcelain scent organ that "plays" an accord in pulses. The old cable runs become scent lines, the runway beam carries the finished charge across the hall, and the visit ends in the Tiziana Terenzi Switch Room. Terenzi began as a candle works (Cereria), so the story starts with wax: the first energy that made light.

The visit, room by room

Hosted groups of up to 14, one every 15 minutes, about 55 minutes in all. Everyone enters at the west hatch and leaves through the hut: one-way, so groups never cross.

1. **Intake** (meter hall), 4 min. A cool, almost scentless room in white glazed brick. Your ticket is a stiff 1920s-style *meter card*. One note only: warm beeswax from a single (flameless) Terenzi candle under glass, "before the current, there was wax". Sound: a distant 50-cycle hum that grows as you walk east.
2. **Fuel Store** (raw materials), 8 min. Brass coal-scuttle hoppers along the wall, each holding one natural: Calabrian bergamot, iris root, vetiver, labdanum, oud, a tincture of ambergris. Lift a lid and a short dry-air puff reaches you; nothing hangs in the room. You punch your meter card at the two you like most.
3. **Still Room** (distillation), 8 min. A working 20-litre electric copper alembic runs a timed steam distillation (rose or lavender in season, water and plant matter only, no ethanol). You see the condenser glass fog, hear an amplified drip and smell the hot, green, unfinished distillate: perfume before it is beautiful.
4. **Converter Hall** (the accord), 14 min. The full 12.5 × 10 m volume, cleared back to steel beams and lit like a turbine hall. The Converter sits on the three original plinths: nine brass "pipes" with porcelain insulators, each with a sealed scent cartridge. You walk the south aisle on walk-on glass over the lit zig-zag cable pit, round the organ, to the switchboard on the north wall. **The Throw** (see below) fires the accord in four waves: top, heart, base, then all together.
5. **Battery Room** (charge), 6 min. Your punched card is read at a brass bench. A host fills a 10 ml "cell" (brass-capped vial) from three components matched to your punches: your own small charge to carry. Evenings, it is the atelier.
6. **Switch Room** (Tiziana Terenzi boutique), 15 min, free time. A 1920s switchboard wall in walnut, brass and porcelain: each knife switch you close lights one fragrance bay and presents a tester blotter. Then up the hut stair into the middle of the square.

The signature moment

The Throw. Every 15 minutes one visitor, chosen by their meter card, pulls a reproduction 1920s knife switch (low-voltage, interlocked; it only *looks* dangerous). The hall goes dark; a deep hum rises from transducers inside the plinths, so you feel it in your feet; blue-white light runs along the old cable runs from the switchboard to the organ; the Converter's pipes light one after another as each fires its note; and the original chain-hoist trolley carries a glowing glass *charge flask* along the runway beam overhead to the Battery Room door. Four minutes, one accord, one photograph from the glass floor looking up at the flask crossing the beams.

Making it super cool

- **The Converter (scent organ).** Nine sealed cartridges in brass bells at nose height, dry-air micro-dosing triggered per note (Scentys/Olfacom-class hardware, not nebulised oil). Each bell has a **downdraught extract** at the plinth base, so a note clears in about 60 seconds. One accord per show keeps the visit inside the "about 7 distinct scents" limit from the research.
- **Scent lines on the cable runs.** New frosted-glass and brass tubes clipped to fresh rails *beside* the original porcelain cleats (cleats untouched). Light pulses travel along them; scent is released only at nodes by the doors, so the "current" is seen everywhere and smelt only where intended.
- **The runway beam lives again.** The trolley moves a 3–4 kg lit glass flask (no liquid above people; the flask is a resin replica). If the original beam fails its load test, a slim new track runs alongside and the original stays as heritage.
- **Walk-on glass over the zig-zag pit.** The machine pit is lit from inside and filled with the raw materials of room 2 in bulk (sealed under the glass): you walk over the fuel.
- **Sound as current.** A tuned hum (low, never loud) in the plinths, and the Elizabeth line rumble 11–14 m below folded into the score instead of fought.
- **Inert, sealed 1920s materials.** White glazed brick tile, brass, porcelain, bakelite-look controls, sealed concrete floor. They are the switchgear look *and* the right answer to odour soak (the research says bare brick will hold every scent). One "as found" bay of original wall stays behind glass.
- **Meter card ritual.** Your ticket is punched room by room; the punches set your Battery Room charge and, if you buy, are printed on the bottle label as your "reading".
- **Light on DMX.** Warm carbon-filament glow by day, cold arc-blue only during the Throw; slow swells, no strobe (photosensitivity).

Above ground

- **Arrival:** the rebuilt steel hatch by the western railings, flush and closed outside slot times. The host meets the group at the west gate 3 minutes before the slot; the ticket QR opens the hatch. Slots are 15 minutes apart, so at most one group (≤14) stands at the railings and nobody queues on the lawn.
- **Exit through the hut:** you climb into the centre of the square, which is the second surprise of the visit. The hut stays a bare protected stair head (no sign, no display, no till); its doors are opened by staff only in operating hours.
- **Garden etiquette:** nothing new on the lawn, no signage beyond a small brass plate at the hatch, no deliveries through the garden in public hours (stock comes in by trolley through the west hatch before opening). Night events need the garden managers' agreement to keep the west path and hut route open after the square closes (to be negotiated; not assumed).

Formats & money

All figures are **estimates**, prices include VAT.

FORMAT	PRICE	NOTES
Current (day visit, 55 min, hosted)	£28 (£22 concession); £10 of it redeemable in the Switch Room	14 per slot, every 15 min, Tue–Sun 11:00–19:00
Night Load (nocturne, extended Throw, non-alcoholic pairing)	£65	2 slots × 14, Thu–Sat after hours
Charge atelier (make a 30 ml extrait from the organ's accord)	£140	6 people, in the Battery Room plus hall
Commission (Terenzi London bespoke, from the meter-card profile)	from £1,200; full bespoke on application	by appointment
Private hire / launches of the whole hall with a custom Throw	£3,500–£6,000 per evening	events only if the two-stair (Scenario C) capacity is approved; otherwise ≤60 total

- **Capacity:** 14 per slot; with three groups in sequence plus boutique browsers and staff the peak stays under 60 below ground.
- **Terenzi's role:** the Switch Room is a Terenzi monobrand boutique (the brand has none in London); Terenzi operates it, keeps the margin and pays a turnover rent, or the operator buys wholesale. Terenzi also co-curates the Converter's accords each season.
- **Non-obvious line: "1132"**, a numbered annual extrait composed on the Converter and named after the door stencil "SOHO SQUARE GARDENS / 1132", sold only in the Switch Room, plus licensing the Throw show (organ score + light cue file) to Terenzi's other boutiques for launches.
- **Rough annual revenue (estimate):** about 40,000 day visitors at ~45% slot occupancy → tickets ≈ £0.85m net; boutique 25% conversion × £160 ≈ £1.3m net; Night Load ≈ £0.2m; atelier ≈ £0.25m; hire ≈ £0.2m; bespoke and 1132 ≈ £0.25m. **Total ≈ £3.0m net, range £1.8m–£3.8m.** Capex likely at the upper half of the dossier's £2.4m–£5.3m range because of the Converter and beam works (organ itself perhaps £0.3m–£0.6m, unquoted).

Fit with the constraints

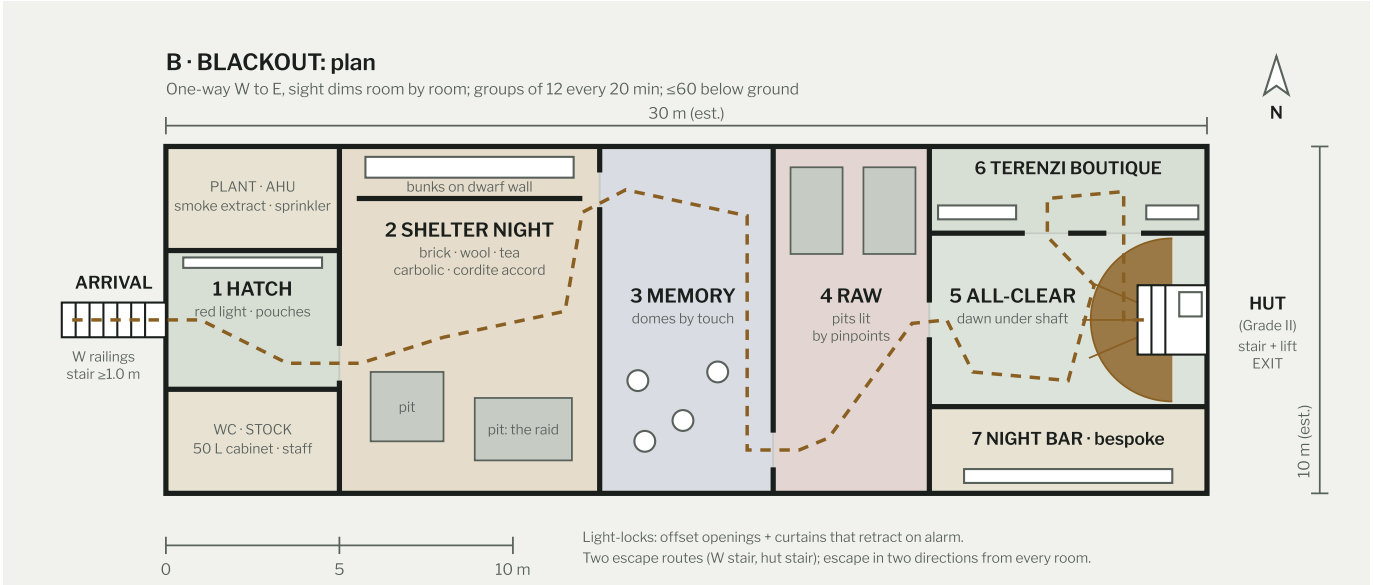
- **Fire:** designed for Scenario B (rebuilt west stair in, rebuilt hut stair out, ≤60 below ground), with sprinklers plus mechanical smoke extract (ADB s.18 route). One-way flow keeps travel distances short and both exits on the route. Perfume stock in a 30-minute store; organ cartridges hold millilitres, not litres; the alembic distils water and plant matter only, on electric heat.
- **Heritage:** plinths, pits, cleats, beam and hut are kept and read as the exhibit. The organ stands on a steel frame bearing on pads (reversible, no fixings into the plinths); scent lines and lights on new rails; one bay left as found. The hut changes only by the stair rebuild needed anyway (LBC).
- **HVAC:** six zones; the Hall, Fuel Store and Still Room are each slightly negative to the route, with carbon-filtered extract; the organ's downdraught is the main extract in the hall, ducted at floor level (whether old conduits can carry it is speculation until surveyed). The still adds heat and moisture: local hood plus dehumidification. Acoustic lining for train rumble.
- **Accessibility:** step-free only if a platform lift is achieved, at the hut (Scenario B) or the west hatch (option 2, consent-dependent); if only the hut lift, wheelchair users enter there and do the route east-to-west with a host. Ramps over dwarf walls; the glass over the pit is flush. Refuges at both stairs. Hum kept below discomfort levels; quiet, low-scent "sensory" slots weekly; no live flame anywhere.
- **Honest gap:** the 30 × 10 m footprint, the position of the plinths and the beam's capacity are all unmeasured. The plan places three plinths in the middle third as an assumption.

Risks

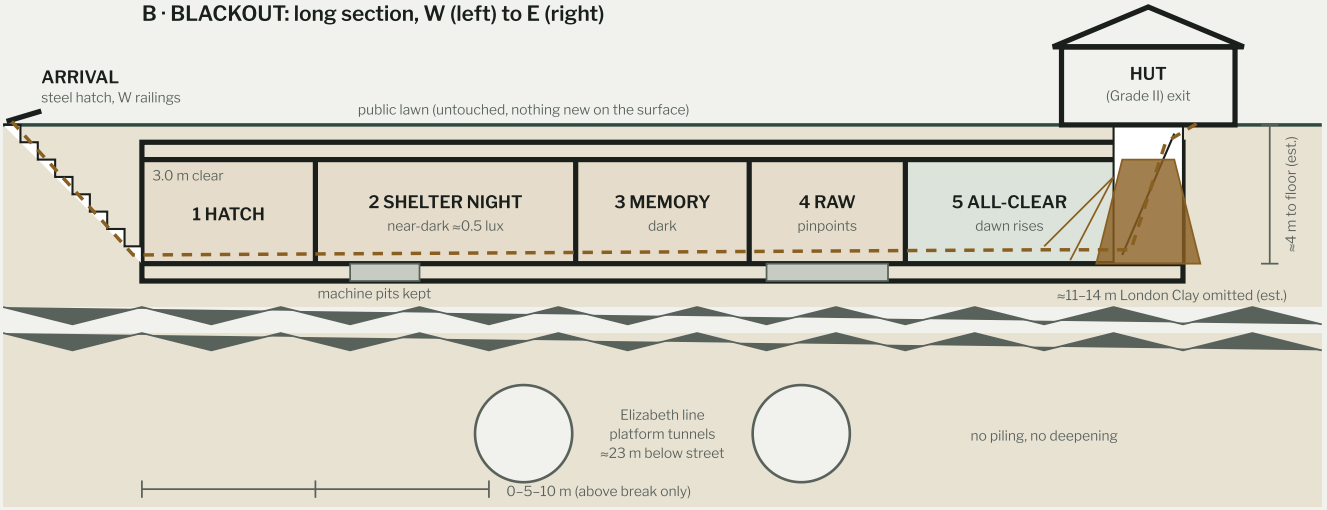
- **The runway beam may not be certifiable** to move anything over visitors. Fallback: a new parallel track or a fixed flask that "charges" with light alone; the moment still works, less spectacularly.
- **Scent clearance in a 125 m² hall** may be slower than a 15-minute cycle needs, leaving residue that muddies the next Throw. Prototype the organ and downdraught at full scale before fit-out; reduce to two waves if needed.
- **UK Power Networks may still hold rights or live equipment** in part of the old substation (dossier §8), which could take a plinth or the switchboard wall out of the plan.

B Blackout

Leave your phone at the hatch, go down into the dark, and let your nose see you through to the all-clear.



Floor plan, 1:200 at 20 px/m. 30 × 10 m hall, about 297 m^2. West stair = arrival, hut stair = second exit.



Long section, west to east. Depths are estimates until measured.

The idea

On a raid night in 1940–41, Londoners in this room could barely see. They knew the night by smell: wet brick, damp wool, stewed tea, carbolic soap, and the smoke drifting down the stair. BLACKOUT rebuilds that night as a 55-minute sensory journey for groups of 12. Phones are sealed at the hatch. Light falls room by room until sight is nearly gone and smell takes over. The route runs one way, west

to east, from the 1940s shelter, to what people remembered and missed, to the rare raw materials of perfumery, each found by touch in the old machine pits. It ends under the hut shaft with the all-clear: the siren's steady note, a slow dawn falling down the shaft, and a Tiziana Terenzi fragrance released like first light. You come up through the Grade II hut into the square. The earlier plan was a hosted museum with a nocturne; this variant makes the darkness itself the exhibit.

The visit, room by room

A new group of 12 enters every 20 minutes, so about three groups are underground at once (36 visitors plus up to 5 staff and about 10 people browsing the boutique, kept at or under 60). Each dark room is used for no more than 14 of every 20 minutes, which leaves at least 6 minutes for a fresh-air purge before the next group.

1. Hatch (light-lock), 6 min. You come down the rebuilt west stair into a small room lit only in deep red. Phones go into lockable pouches that you keep (Yondr-type; they open at the end). A host in a warden's coat gives a two-minute briefing: what to do if you want to leave (raise the glow-pebble you have been given; a host comes within seconds), where the exits are, what the lights do in an alarm. Red light starts your night vision, because the rods in the eye barely respond to red. You smell nothing yet. The air here is deliberately neutral, so it works as the "zero" your nose is measured against. *See:* red. *Hear:* muffled traffic from the square, fading. *Do:* seal your phone, take your ration card (a card holding six blank smelling strips).

2. Shelter Night, 14 min. Light drops to about 0.5 lux, enough to make out shapes. Bunks are stacked along the north dwarf wall, and the two machine pits are sunk into the floor. Two scents are diffused at room scale: damp brick and earth, then wet wool. Others are handed to you: tea from an enamel mug (real tea), a bar under a glass dome that smells of carbolic soap, and, as the raid starts, a strip carrying a cordite-and-smoke accord. Every one of these is reconstructed by a perfumer from safe, IFRA-compliant materials, with no real explosive residue and no free phenol. The raid is sound and touch: low thuds through floor transducers, plaster dust (a scent, not real dust), the warden's voice counting heads. *See:* almost nothing. *Hear:* the raid in ambisonic sound, a gramophone, someone singing. *Do:* sit on a bunk, hold the mug, find your neighbour's hand if you want to.

3. Memory, 10 min. Fully dark, apart from the hooded exit signs. Oral-history voices (licensing to be agreed with an archive such as IWM; speculation) talk about what people missed: oranges, Sunday roast, a mother's face powder (iris and violet), a seaside summer before the war. Each memory has a warm brass smelling dome at hand height. You find it by touch, lift the lid, and the scent sits only inside the dome, so the room never mixes. *Smell:* orange, roast, face powder, sea air, coal fire. *Do:* follow a handrail with knurled marks at each dome.

4. Raw, 10 min. In the dark, a single fibre-optic pinpoint wakes above each machine pit. By now your eyes are fully adapted, so a point of light the size of a match head feels like a lamp. In each pit sits one rare raw material in an open sealed vessel: ambergris tincture, oud, orris butter, labdanum, jasmine absolute, and a Romagna note from the Terenzi family's own coast (to be chosen with them). A perfumer's voice tells you what each costs and where it comes from. These are the notes the final fragrance is built from. *Do:* add one of the six to your ration card, on a strip the host dips for you.

5. All-Clear, 6 min. Silence, full dark. Then the all-clear: a steady siren note, softer than the original. Over 90 seconds a warm light falls down the glazed hut-shaft stair enclosure, from deep amber to white, like dawn coming down a well. As it reaches the floor, a single burst of dry-air diffusion releases a Tiziana Terenzi extrait across the room. Your pouch unlocks on the base under the shaft. The first photograph most people take is of the light in the shaft. *Smell:* the dawn fragrance (a rotating Terenzi extrait; at launch possibly a London edition, subject to Terenzi).

6. Terenzi Boutique, 10+ min (open-ended). A long, lit gallery along the north side, warm brass and black glass, with the full range on testers and dummy flacons only (HSG51). Your ration card becomes your shopping list: the host smells your six strips with you and points to the fragrances built on them. Discovery sets, candles (never lit), and a London-only "Blackout" discovery box sit by the stair foot. Exit is up the rebuilt hut stair or the platform lift, into the square.

7. Night Bar and bespoke (evening and by appointment). The south wing is a small counter for bespoke consultations by day and the bar for the late format at night. It is never part of the dark route.

The signature moment

The all-clear. Sixty minutes after giving up your phone and most of your sight, you stand under the hut shaft in total dark. The siren sounds, dawn falls down the stair, the room fills with a Terenzi fragrance, and your phone wakes in your hand. The post is the shot straight up the shaft into the light, and then the photo taken outside at the hut doors, blinking in the square. It works because everyone gets the same picture and it cannot be taken any other way.

Making it super cool

1. **Light-locks, not doors.** Each room joins the next through offset openings and a short serpentine baffle, lined with heavy blackout curtains on magnetic tracks. The plan alone keeps light from bleeding between rooms, and the curtains retract automatically on fire alarm.
2. **Dark-adaptation choreography.** A red-light briefing, then 0.5 lux, then darkness lit only by hooded exit signs, then pinpoints. By room 4 your eyes are adapted enough that a fibre-optic point reads as a lamp, so very little light goes a long way.
3. **Scent that never mixes.** Dry-air, presence-triggered micro-diffusion (Scentys or Olfacom type), at most two room-scale atmospheres per room and six to eight scents in total, with everything else in closed domes or on strips. Each room is kept slightly negative to the next, with carbon-filtered extract and a 6-minute fresh-air purge between groups.
4. **The ration card.** A buff card, printed like a 1940s ration book, with six slots for smelling strips the visitor fills on the way. It is the souvenir, the boutique's shopping list, and the follow-up email ("your six notes").
5. **Sound through the body.** Ambisonic speakers for the raid and the voices, plus floor transducers kept to safe, gentle levels. The real rumble of trains far below is folded into the soundtrack rather than fought, with acoustic lining for the rest.
6. **Temperature and air as scenery.** Room 2 runs cool and slightly damp to the touch (16 °C). Room 5 warms by about 4 °C as dawn arrives, with a gentle air movement down the shaft, so the all-clear is felt on the skin as well.
7. **Infrared hosting.** Hosts wear infrared night-vision monoculars and the control room watches IR CCTV, so staff see the dark clearly even when visitors cannot. A visitor who raises the glow-pebble is met in seconds and led out along the lit escape route.
8. **The heritage is the set.** The substation's own plinths, pits, dwarf walls, chain-hoist runway beam and porcelain cable cleats carry the bunks, domes and raw materials. Nothing hides them. A small "as found" panel stays behind glass in room 2.

Above ground

- **Arrival at the hatch.** Timed tickets only. A text arrives 10 minutes before your slot ("Your warden is at the west hatch"). One host waits at the rebuilt steel hatch inside the west railings, takes 12 names and leads you down. There is no kiosk, no queue line and no signage on the lawn beyond a small plate on the railings. If you are early, you sit on the existing garden benches like anyone else.
- **Exit through the hut.** Groups come up through the hut's south doors in twos and threes over a few minutes, so there is never a crowd at the hut. The hut stays a bare protected stair head (ADB 3.38), with no shop and no ticket desk in it, and its exterior is unchanged.
- **Step-free.** Wheelchair users and anyone who cannot use the stair arrive at the hut and go down in the platform lift (Scenario B), are met by a host and taken along the lit route to room 1 before their group, then follow the same visit. Every floor change on the route is ramped.
- **Garden etiquette.** No amplified sound above ground, no costumes outside, no gatherings at the hatch. Evening formats run after the garden closes only if Westminster agrees a managed-access arrangement for the west gate and the hut path (speculation; this is a negotiation, not a given). The Dawn format (below) uses the garden at sunrise on the same condition.

Formats & money

Ticket ladder (all estimates, incl. VAT):

FORMAT	WHEN	GROUP	PRICE
BLACKOUT (standard)	Tue–Sun, 10:00–19:00, every 20 min	12	£38 off-peak, £44 weekend; concession £30; age 10+
Relaxed BLACKOUT	Weekday mornings, monthly	8	£30 (more light, longer rooms, no raid sound)
NIGHT RAID (late)	Thu–Sat 20:00–23:00, 3 slots	12	£75: longer raid with live voice or cello, one paired drink at the Night Bar (licence needed)
DAWN ALL-CLEAR	Once a month around sunrise, 2 groups	12	£95: the finale is timed to real sunrise and you climb out into an empty square
Private buy-out	Evenings	up to 36	£4,000–£6,000
Bespoke consultation	By appointment	1–2	from £750 (Floris benchmark), full bespoke via Terenzi

Capacity per slot: 12 visitors; about 3 slots underground at once; up to 60 people below ground in total, staff included. At 27 day slots a day, that is about 324 places a day and about 100,000 a year at 310 days.

Terenzi boutique role. The boutique is the profit engine. Terenzi runs it (no monobrand Terenzi store exists in London; it opened Rome in 2025 and Milan in 2026). The ticket includes a £10 credit against a full-size purchase, redeemable the same day. Assume 25% conversion at about £160 average transaction (estimate, as in the earlier research).

Non-obvious revenue line: licensing the Shelter Accords. The reconstructed 1940s scents (brick, wool, tea, carbolic, cordite-smoke, face powder, wartime orange) become a licensed library: scent kits for museums, schools and film or theatre productions, and "reminiscence boxes" for dementia-care providers, where smell is used to prompt memory. It also gives the museum a public-benefit story Westminster can point to.

Rough annual revenue (net of VAT and fees; estimate):

STREAM	MID CASE
BLACKOUT tickets: ~60k visitors at 60% occupancy, ~£30 net	£1.80m
NIGHT RAID: ~3,500 a year at ~£58 net	£0.20m
DAWN, Relaxed: small volumes	£0.03m
Private buy-outs: ~60 a year at ~£4k	£0.24m
Boutique: 25% × £160, net of VAT, after the £10 credit	£0.55m (operator margin depends on the deal with Terenzi)
Shelter Accords licensing and kits	£0.05–0.10m
Total	**about £2.9m mid (estimate; range £1.6m at 35% occupancy to £3.8m at 80%)**

This is higher than the earlier plan's £2.0m mid case, because three groups of 12 move through in parallel instead of one hosted group. It is also more exposed to occupancy, and 60,000 a year is above Hidden London's 48,630 across all its sites. Treat the top end with caution.

Fit with the constraints

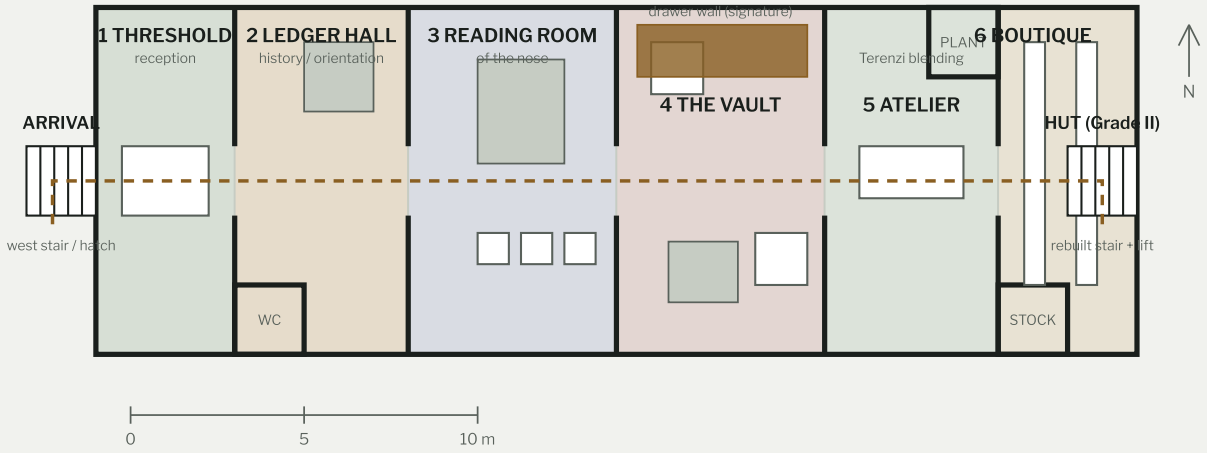
- **Fire, darkness and escape (the honest part).** Darkness is legal only if it is designed with building control and the fire engineer from the start. Precedents exist: cinemas and theatres run in near-dark with maintained exit signs, and dark-exhibition formats such as Dialogue in the Dark and dining-in-the-dark restaurants have operated in many cities (precedent to check, not verified here). The design rests on these points:
    - Two protected escape stairs, the rebuilt west stair and the rebuilt hut stair, both at least 1000 mm (Scenario B), with escape in two directions from every room and a cap of 60 people below ground, staff included.
    - Exit signs stay lit at all times (they cannot be switched off). They are fitted in shallow hoods that keep them fully visible along the escape route but stop them washing the room.
    - Escape-route lighting is designed to BS 5266. On any fire alarm or mains failure, the show system is overridden and every room goes to full light within a second (fail to light). The blackout curtains retract on the same signal, and the voice alarm takes over the soundtrack.
    - Low-level photoluminescent wayfinding strips and a continuous handrail run along the route.
    - Sprinklers plus mechanical smoke extract (ADB Section 18), as in the earlier plan. All curtains and linings are to a fire classification agreed with building control.
    - No flame anywhere. Perfume stock is held in a 50 L flammables cabinet in the store, with testers and dummy flacons on display, and the raw materials in room 4 in sealed vessels with tiny volumes.
    - Hosts carry IR monoculars, hold a live headcount by group (lanyard tag or counted at each light-lock), and rehearse evacuation in the dark.
- **Heritage.** All fit-out is free-standing and reversible. Plinths, pits, dwarf walls, the runway beam and the porcelain cleats stay in view. The hut's exterior is unchanged; its stair is rebuilt inside under listed building consent. The hatch is rebuilt within its existing footprint.
- **HVAC.** Four separately zoned scent rooms, each slightly negative, with carbon-filtered extract and a timed purge, plus a separate supply to the boutique. Plant sits in the north-west corner (sprinkler tank, pumps, AHU, smoke-extract fans). Where the intake and exhaust surface is unresolved, as for every variant. The likeliest route is within the rebuilt west-stair and hatch footprint (speculation; this needs the M&E engineer and the 1931 Act consent).
- **Accessibility.** Darkness is a leveller for blind and partially sighted visitors, who can use the route on equal terms, and that should be said in the marketing. Wheelchair access depends on the platform lift in the hut shaft, which in turn needs the second stair and, under London Plan D5, probably an evacuation-capable lift. The dwarf walls and pits are bridged by ramps on the route. People with anxiety, claustrophobia or a fear of the dark get the Relaxed format, a host on call, and a lit way out from any room. No strobes or flashing light anywhere (photosensitive epilepsy).

Risks

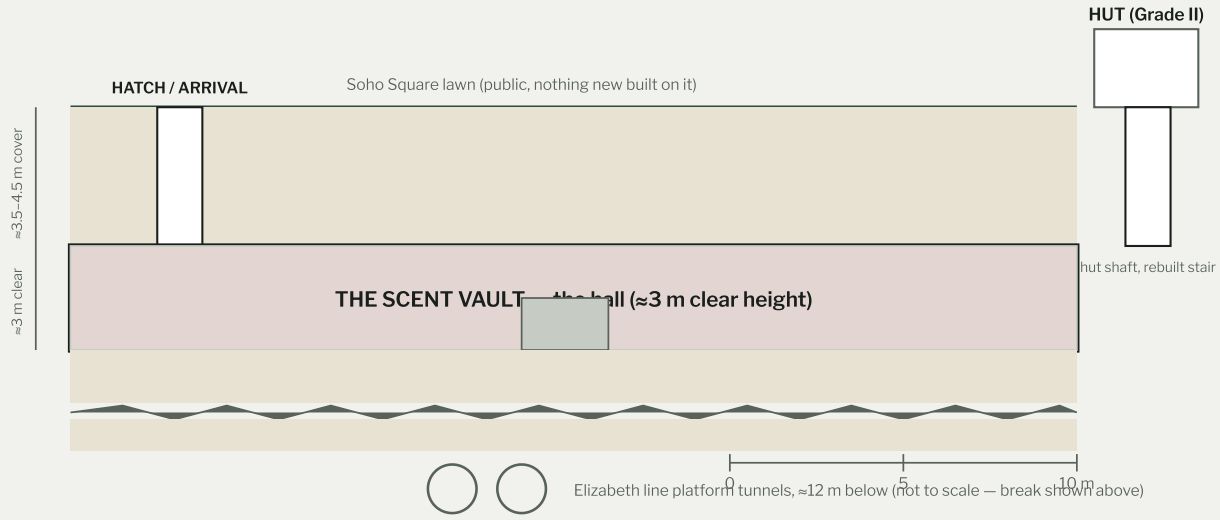
- **Building control or the fire service may refuse near-dark with 60 people underground.** Fallback: a "dusk" level of about 1–2 lux throughout, which keeps most of the effect but loses the full-dark rooms 3 and 5.
- **Smell carry-over and damp.** Porous brick and an all-year damp load could blur the scents and ruin precise rooms. Sealing, dehumidification and extract may cost more than budgeted, and they should be tested on a mock-up room first.
- **Novelty decay and dependence on one partner.** A dark show sells hard in year one and then needs new reasons to return (seasonal raw materials, new Night Raid scripts). If Terenzi steps back, the boutique, which carries the economics, goes with them.

The Scent Vault

A bank for smells you can't get back, and one drawer, with your name on it, that's yours.



Floor plan, 1:200 at 20 px/m. 30 × 10 m hall, about 297 m^2. West stair = arrival, hut stair = second exit.



Long section, west to east. Depths are estimates until measured.

The idea

The shelter was built to hold a 1920s substation's cables and plinths, then became a wartime refuge, then stood bricked up for years. The Scent Vault treats it as what the brick and steel already look like underground: a strongroom. Visitors open an account on arrival, are issued a brass key, and walk a ledger-to-vault sequence that ends in a wall of hundreds of keyed safe-deposit drawers, each holding

a scent that can't be smelled anywhere else, discontinued formulas, reconstructions of historic ones, a rotating "smell of London" archive. Members go further: they deposit a personal, bespoke fragrance formula, built with a Terenzi perfumer, sealed, numbered and stored in their own drawer, exactly as a bank stores a document. It is calm, precise and archival rather than theatrical, a museum that behaves like an institution you can trust with something irreplaceable.

The visit, room by room

1. **Threshold** (3 min) — Reception at the foot of the west hatch, styled as a bank's entrance lobby: a teller-style desk, soft brass light, a single leather ledger. You give your name, are issued a brass token and a blank blotter card. Smell: nothing yet, deliberately, a neutral scrubbed-air lobby so the nose resets from the street.
2. **The Ledger Hall** (7 min) — Orientation room. The substation's own history (1928 converter station, WWII refuge, the "SOHO SQUARE GARDENS 1132" door) told via relics on an original machine plinth, kept as-found behind glass. A short audio piece, no screens. Smell: cold stone, machine oil, a trace of wartime wool, there to place you underground before the perfume starts.
3. **The Reading Room for the Nose** (12 min) — A hushed library: armchairs, a wall of glass smelling domes (Osmothèque method, no diffusion, no contamination), paper blotters you keep. One original sunken machine pit is kept open as a display well. You read short cards and smell discontinued perfumes, extinct raw materials (real ambergris, oakmoss before IFRA limits, synthetic musks that got banned) and early 20th-century London itself: coal smoke, chypre face powder, Thames fog.
4. **The Vault** (15 min) — The signature room. A brass drawer wall along the north wall, your key opens one numbered drawer at a time. Behind it: the "smell of London" rotating collection (fog, wet Berwick Street market, a 1940 shelter night) and a locked tier of members' private deposits, visible, unreachable, exactly like walking past other people's safe-deposit boxes. A vault keeper (not a shop assistant) hosts this room.
5. **The Atelier** (15 min) — Tiziana Terenzi's blending bench. Workshop guests build and bottle their own 30–50 ml scent here. Members who choose to "deposit" go through the full ceremony: formula agreed with the perfumer, decanted, wax-sealed, logged in the ledger, given a numbered brass pendant that is also their vault key.
6. **The Boutique** (10–15 min, unticketed dwell) — Terenzi's range, archive-inspired capsule bottles, and the hut stair exit (second, protected escape route, rebuilt to current standard).

The signature moment

Opening your own drawer in the Vault wall with the key you were given at the door: a cold brass cylinder, a quiet mechanical give, and a scent that exists nowhere else you can go. Members get a second version of this forever, the 400th visit is still "my drawer, my scent".

Making it super cool

- **Keyed brass safe-deposit wall**: hundreds of individually sealed cylinders, each a closed system (one blotter reservoir, no open diffusion), so the signature device is also the HVAC-safest one in the building.
- **The Ledger**: every visit and every deposit logged by hand in a bound ledger with a wax seal, a single continuous institutional record rather than a stamped ticket.
- **Smelling domes, not nebulisers**: the Reading Room uses sealed glass domes and blotters exclusively, so the library never cross-contaminates the Vault next door.
- **Sound as asset, not problem**: Northern/Elizabeth line rumble and the brass drawers' own mechanical clunk are leaned into as ambient "vault sound", not masked.
- **As-found heritage window**: one section of WWII brick and the fuse box plinth kept visible behind glass in the Ledger Hall, everywhere else lined and sealed per conservation/HVAC need.
- **Deposit ceremony**: wax seal, numbered brass pendant, ledger entry, the single most giftable and photographable private ritual in the building.
- **Quarterly rotating archive**: the "smell of London" tier changes every season, so locals re-visit; each scent carries a citation card (archival, not invented).
- **Light and material grammar**: cool bank-vault white light in the Vault, warm library amber in the Reading Room, brass/walnut/glass/inert tile throughout, no plastic, nothing loud.

Above ground

Arrival is through the existing west hatch, discreetly marked, a small brass plaque at the railings reading only "The Scent Vault, by appointment", no banners, no queue barriers. Entry is by named, timed appointment (like a bank), so nobody waits outside in the square. The Grade II hut is rebuilt as the second, protected stair, used for exit only (and step-free access via a platform lift in its shaft, per the dossier's Scenario C precedent), so no new footprint on the lawn and no gathering at the hut doors. Garden etiquette: visitors leave individually or in loose pairs, no grouped dispersal, no signage beyond the one plaque, planting around the hatch kept as is.

Formats & money

All figures are estimates, built on the dossier's comparators, and will move ±30–50% until the space is surveyed.

TICKET	PRICE (INCL. VAT)	WHAT IT IS
Vault Pass (self-guided, Rooms 1–4 + boutique)	£28	Reading Room + Vault only, no host
Hosted Vault Tour (all 6 rooms, 60 min)	£38	Groups of 12, host-led, the core product
Nocturne (flameless candlelight, non-alcoholic pairing)	£65	Evening slots, 2 a night
Atelier Workshop (build your own 30–50 ml)	£145	With a Terenzi perfumer, 8 per session
Deposit Ceremony (one-off, non-member)	£950	Bespoke formula, sealed, one-year drawer storage included

Membership (the private-club layer): Vault Membership, £480/year — a permanent personal drawer, unlimited Reading Room access, member evenings, priority deposit-ceremony booking, and discounted re-formulation if a stored scent needs rebalancing. This is the recurring-revenue spine the research flags as missing from a pure ticket model.

Non-obvious revenue line: the Bequest Service. A member can leave standing instructions for their drawer, released to family on death, donated to the public "smell of London" archive, or destroyed, administered for a one-off £150 filing fee plus the ledger entry. It fits the institution's own conceit (a bank handles bequests) and turns the vault into something people plan around rather than just visit.

Private hire: whole-Vault buyouts for brand launches, weddings (a couple can commission and deposit "the smell of our wedding" as a live event centrepiece), £2,800–£4,200 an evening.

Terenzi's role: runs the Atelier and Boutique as operator/concession (so retail margin of roughly 75–85% sits with Terenzi), supplies the perfumer for every Deposit Ceremony, and the Boutique sells an archive-inspired capsule range exclusive to the Vault.

Capacity, following the dossier's Scenario B/C (rebuilt west stair + rebuilt hut stair, cap ≈60–70 at once): groups of 12 every 30 min across 10 day slots ≈ 37k hosted places/year; plus Reading Room self-guided passes and the boutique. **Rough net revenue, mid case: ≈£1.8m–£2.2m/year** (hosted journeys + nocturnes + atelier + membership + boutique + bequest fees), broadly in line with the dossier's £2.0m mid-case, with membership and bequest fees adding a thin but sticky layer on top. **Estimate, unverified.**

Fit with the constraints

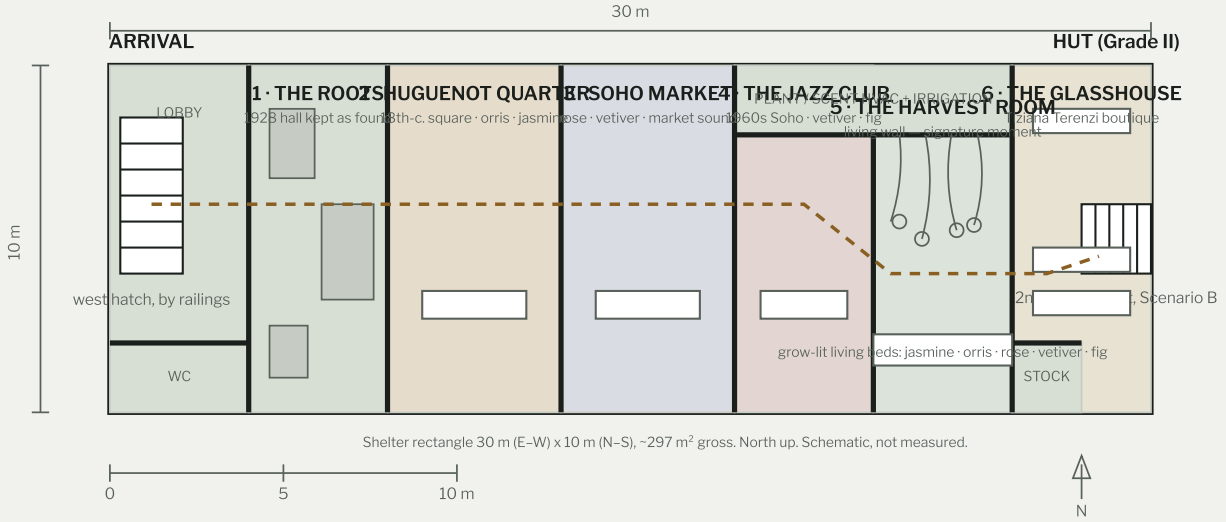
- **Fire:** needs Scenario B/C (rebuilt west stair ≥1000 mm *and* the hut shaft rebuilt as a protected stair) to use the full 30 m plan and lift the 18 m travel-distance limit; under Scenario A only, Rooms 5–6 (Atelier, Boutique, hut exit) would sit outside the usable zone, a real risk if the second stair isn't achievable. Occupancy stays under the ~60–70 cap by design (groups of 12, staggered).
- **Heritage:** machine plinths and one brick/concrete bay kept visible as-found; everything else lined per HVAC need. Hut touched only for the stair/lift, both needing Listed Building Consent.
- **HVAC:** the Vault's sealed-drawer design is the safest-possible olfactory device (no open diffusion); Reading Room uses blotters/domes only; Atelier is the one room needing full DSEAR-compliant alcohol handling (dummy flacons on display, ≤50 L cabinet, bulk stock off-site).
- **Accessibility:** step-free only if a platform lift fits the hut shaft (unverified, needs a measured survey); fallback is a surface/virtual Vault experience and a take-home scent kit, as the dossier's Clapham South precedent suggests.

Risks

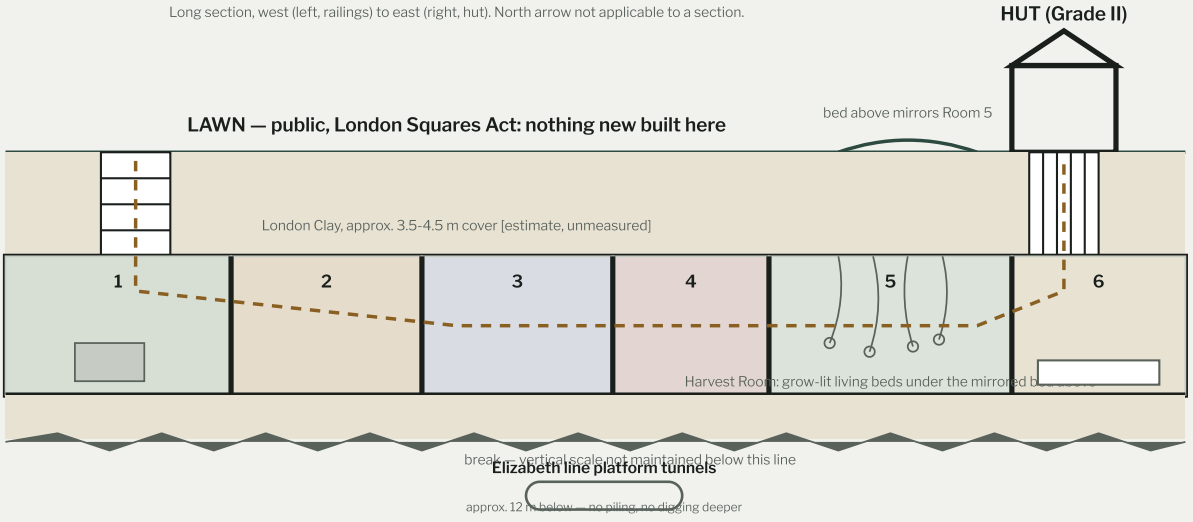
- The whole plan leans on the second escape route existing; if only Scenario A is achievable, the Atelier and Boutique (and the signature Vault drawer wall, if placed east of 18 m) may not fit.
- Membership and the Bequest Service promise long-term custody of physical scent and legal instructions, real reputational and insurance exposure if a stored fragrance degrades or a bequest is mishandled; needs proper underwriting, not just a ledger.
- Underground damp and cool temperatures (good for scent storage) require dehumidification running year-round for the brass vault wall and sealed drawers; any plant failure threatens the stored collection, not just comfort.

The Garden Below

Soho Square turned upside down: the lawn you just walked across is growing, lit and breathing, right over your head.



Floor plan, 1:200 at 20 px/m. 30 × 10 m hall, about 297 m². West stair = arrival, hut stair = second exit.



Long section, west to east. Depths are estimates until measured.

The idea

Soho Square's garden is public and untouchable (London Squares Act, 1931 Act) — so this variant doesn't compete with it, it mirrors it. Underground, directly beneath the beds and plane trees above, a botanical olfactory garden hangs from the ceiling: sculpted roots tracing the real planting above, grow-lit beds of living jasmine, orris, rose, vetiver and fig growing in genuine cultivation (not diffused

scent — actual plants under horticultural LED). The walk tells 300 years of what this one patch of London has smelled of: the 18th-century aristocratic square, the Huguenot silk-and-soap quarter, Soho's street markets, a 1960s jazz club, and finally the live "harvest" itself. Seasonal exhibitions are synced with what's actually flowering in the real garden overhead. It ends in Tiziana Terenzi's boutique, built as a steel-and-glass glasshouse. Joyful, green, family-friendly, and the strongest public-benefit story of any variant on the table: a museum that gives the council's garden back to it, underground.

The visit, room by room

A hosted walk for groups of up to 14, about 70 minutes, west to east along the shelter's full 30 m length (two protected escape stairs, Scenario B, so the 18 m single-direction limit doesn't bite).

1. **Arrival & The Roots** (8 min) — descend the west hatch into the lobby, under a canopy of cast "root" sculptures tracing the real plane trees and beds above (position data from a garden survey [estimate: exact root architecture is artistic licence, not a scan of actual roots]). The 1928 machine hall's hoist, plinths and cable cleats are kept as found underneath the canopy — the site's own history as the foundation the garden grows from. One diffused "wet soil and leaf" atmosphere.
2. **The Huguenot Quarter** (10 min) — 18th-century Soho: silk weavers, wig powder, tallow and the first physic-garden planting of the square. Smelling strips of orris root and jasmine (the weavers' perfumers' trade). Panelling references silk-loom timber.
3. **Soho Market** (10 min) — Berwick Street and the street markets: fish, cut flowers, veg, roasting coffee, tobacco. Rose and vetiver on blotters; a market-stall soundscape (barrow wheels, cries, bus brakes).
4. **The Jazz Club** (10 min) — 1950s–60s Soho nightlife: smoke, leather banquettes, spilled whisky. Vetiver and fig, low red light, a looping horn line. The smallest, densest room, deliberately claustrophobic before the next room opens up.
5. **The Harvest Room** (18 min, the signature stop) — the living wall: jasmine, orris, rose, vetiver and fig growing under broad-spectrum grow-lights set into the ceiling exactly where the beds sit above, roots visibly hanging through an open lattice ceiling. A seasonal "harvest" exhibition (what's actually blooming upstairs, this week) with a small working still. Visitors can touch, smell and occasionally take a cutting.
6. **The Glasshouse (Tiziana Terenzi boutique)** (15–20 min) — a steel-and-glass greenhouse structure built inside the hall. Testers and dummy flacons on display; stock in a fire-rated 30-minute store per HSG51. Exit back up the west stair, timed against the next group's descent.

The signature moment

Standing under the Harvest Room's open lattice ceiling, surrounded by real growing jasmine, rose, vetiver, orris and fig under a canopy of hanging cast roots, with a live camera feed showing the actual bed overhead at that exact moment — the thing people photograph and post is "the garden is growing *under* the garden."

Making it super cool

- **Living wall, not diffusion** — real cultivated plants under horticultural LED "false sun" panels is the one device no rival perfume museum has; everyone else diffuses or distills, nobody grows.
- **Root canopy installation** — cast resin/fibre roots in the lobby and Harvest Room, lit to pulse gently, mapped to a wind sensor on the real trees above [estimate: a nice-to-have gimmick, needs a live data feed from a rooftop or tree-mounted sensor].
- **Live garden camera** — a discreet rooftop feed of the actual bed above the Harvest Room, shown on a screen at the "harvest" moment, so the underground and overground gardens visibly sync.
- **Scent discipline** — at most one diffused atmosphere per room plus closed smelling domes and blotters for everything else (the Osmothèque method; the Paris natural-history museum trial found visitors can reliably place only ~7 scents per visit).
- **Soundscape layering** — bone-conduction headsets per room (market cries, jazz horns, birdsong) so rooms don't bleed into each other acoustically either.
- **Materials** — reclaimed Soho shopfront tile and timber in rooms 2–4, then glasshouse glass, painted steel and cork flooring from room 5 onward — a visible material shift from "street" to "garden."
- **Take-home ritual** — every visitor leaves with a tagged seed packet or rooted cutting from that week's harvest, dated to their visit.
- **"Adopt a plant" naming wall** — small brass tags in the Harvest Room sponsored by schools, families or the Soho Society; ties the museum into the square's own community rather than just monetising it.

Above ground

Arrival is the existing west hatch by the railings — nothing new on the lawn, no kiosk, no queue (1931 Act, London Squares Preservation Act). Guests check in by phone/QR at the gate; groups are staggered so nobody waits visibly on the grass. The hut (Grade II) is rebuilt as the second protected escape stair plus a platform lift shaft (Scenario B) — it stays an empty stair head, no retail or signage in it, consistent with its listing. A single discreet brass plaque by the hatch; no signage visible from the square's sightlines. The "live garden camera" used inside is the only piece of kit on the lawn itself, disguised as an ordinary bird-box or lamp fitting [estimate: needs WCC and the Garden Committee's sign-off either way].

Formats & money

All figures are estimates, ±30–50%, pending a measured survey — see the dossier.

TICKET	PRICE (INCL. VAT)	NOTES
Standard walk	£28 adult / £16 child	the six-room, 70-min hosted walk
Family ticket	£78 (2 adults + 2 children)	positions the museum as a family day out, not just a brand experience
Twilight Garden (evening, grow-lights on full, no alcohol)	£42	two evening slots a day
Harvest Workshop (seed-planting / cutting, kids)	£18 per child, 45 min	school holidays and weekends
Private hire / launch	£3,000–£4,500 evening buy-out	Terenzi launches, corporate, garden-charity events

- **Capacity:** groups of 14 every 30 min, two protected escape routes (Scenario B) lifting the single-stair 60-person cap; design occupancy ~55–70 at once on a normal day, up to ~150 for an evening event per the dossier's two-stair reading.
- **Terenzi boutique role:** the Glasshouse is Terenzi-operated (keeps the 75–85% retail margin with them, not an operating company); estimated 25–30% conversion at the exit of a room that has just shown visitors real rose, orris, vetiver and fig growing, against a £140–£180 average spend.
- **Non-obvious revenue line:** a mail-order/online "Grow Your Own Soho Garden" kit (orris, jasmine or fig cutting + a Terenzi-branded scent-matched candle), sold year-round off the museum's own propagation, not just at the till — turns the living wall into a standing product line rather than a one-off visit upsell.
- **Rough annual revenue [estimate]:** mid case ≈ £1.7m–£2.1m net (tickets + workshops + private hire + boutique + grow-kits), broadly in line with the dossier's §5b mid case, with family/workshop tickets adding volume the dossier's adult-only model didn't price.

Fit with the constraints

- **Fire:** depends on the hut being successfully rebuilt as a genuine second protected stair (Scenario B) — if WCC/Historic England refuse that, the plan compresses to rooms 1–3 only within the 18 m single-route limit, and the Harvest Room's signature moment moves to the middle of the walk instead of the end. Honest risk, not a given.
- **Heritage:** machine pits, plinths and the hoist runway are kept as found and worked into Room 1 rather than removed; the hut's listed fabric is touched only for the stair/lift it already needs under Scenario B.
- **HVAC:** this variant adds a genuinely new M&E load the dossier didn't price — a living-plant room needs its own irrigation, drainage, humidity and grow-light heat load on top of the scent-room extract already required for Rooms 2–4. Budget an extra horticultural plant allowance beyond the dossier's §5a HVAC line [estimate, not costed here].
- **Accessibility:** step-free depends on the same platform lift at the west hatch the base dossier already flags (£60k–£150k); the Harvest Room's lattice ceiling and uneven planting beds need a firm, level visitor path cut through them for wheelchair and pushchair access — doable, but a specific design constraint this variant adds.

Risks

- **Living plants are a live system, not a fixed exhibit** — a failed crop, pest outbreak or lighting fault before a scheduled "harvest" event is a real operational risk with no easy understudy; needs a horticulturist on staff, not just hosts.
- **Humidity conflict**: fragrance wants 40–60% RH and the plants want comparable or higher humidity near the grow-beds, but the shelter is already damp-prone and historically bricked-up — the two systems can probably be zoned apart, but that's an added engineering ask on top of the dossier's §4a scent-room design, not proven here.
- **Second-escape dependency**: the whole six-room, 30 m-long, family-pitched version of this variant needs the hut rebuilt as a working protected stair (Scenario B); if that fails, both the room count and the family-ticket economics shrink together.

SIDE BY SIDE

Four directions, one recommendation

	A · SUBSTATION	B · BLACKOUT	C · SCENT VAULT	D · GARDEN BELOW
Feels like	Industrial theatre, brass and porcelain	Immersive, dark, emotional	Quiet, archival, private-club	Green, joyful, family
Signature moment	Pull the 1928 knife switch: the scent organ fires	Siren, then dawn falls down the hut shaft	Your own named drawer in the vault	Harvest room growing under the lawn
Core ticket	£28	£38–44	£38 hosted	£28 (family £78)
Group / slot	14 every 15 min	12 every 20 min	12 every 30 min	14 every 30 min
Net revenue, mid (estimate)	~£3.0m	~£2.9m (aggressive)	members + tickets, lower volume	~£1.7–2.1m
Unusual money line	"1132" numbered yearly perfume	Shelter-scent kits for schools, theatre, dementia care	Bequest service for drawers	Grow-your-own Soho garden kits
Fits the heritage	Best: uses plinths, cable runs, hoist beam	Good: WWII layer	Good: reversible fit-out	Weakest: plants and humidity in a damp chamber
Council / Soho Society appeal	High: tells the true 1928 story	Medium: dark rooms worry building control	Medium: reads as private	Highest: families, schools, the garden
Hardest risk	Hoist beam load test; scent clearing between shows	Near-dark with 60 people may be refused	Feels exclusive; slow volume	Damp, light and water underground; scent mixing

Revenue figures come from each studio's own model and are not yet comparable. All of them sit above the 27/09 plan's £2.0m mid case, and B assumes more visitors than Hidden London gets across all its sites. Treat them as upside, not a forecast.

My call: build A, put C inside it, and run B at night

- **The Substation is the spine.** Westminster now officially calls the space a transformer chamber, and the photos show a machine hall. A design that tells the true 1928 story is the most authentic and the hardest to copy, and it gives the heritage officers something to protect, not object to.
- **The Vault lives in its walls.** Put C's numbered drawers along the converter hall, where the switchgear panels were. Membership at about £480 a year and deposit ceremonies at about £950 give recurring income that does not depend on footfall.
- **Blackout is the late format.** Thursday to Saturday nights the lights go down and the hall becomes the shelter. That gives B's emotional peak without asking building control to approve permanent darkness.

- **Borrow D's public side for the council.** School sessions, one free community morning a month, a public toilet at hatch level and a link to the Museum of Soho. These cost little and make the public-benefit case for a below-market lease.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

Six steps, each cheap, before any money is committed

1. **Today, Tim Lord (12:30).** Show the variants, ask which one the Soho Society would back in writing, and ask for introductions to Revd Adam Scott (frontages trustees) and Tony Shrimplin (Museum of Soho).
2. **This week.** Write one letter to the Corporate Landlord mailbox. It puts a hosted perfume museum forward as a second option next to custodianship, at no cost to the council.
3. **This week.** Sound out Tiziana Terenzi (Paolo and Tiziana) through Cere's channels about a London flagship underground. Ask for a letter of intent, not a contract.
4. **By 26/10.** Read the FOI answer. Order the Land Registry title (£3) and the SIM search (£8), which are inside the spending you have already approved.
5. **When the council agrees to a viewing.** Commission a measured survey with laser scan and gas/damp readings (about £1.5–3k, needs your go). Have a fire engineer test the two-stair scheme.
6. **Then.** Pick one variant, prepare a pre-application with Westminster planning and Historic England, and agree TfL asset protection (Elizabeth line below).

Prepared by Mia for Alessandro Ticchi, 13/10/2026. Dimensions are estimates from photographs and 2015 press reports. Nothing here has been measured. Site photos: 28DaysLater, Forever Changes, Subterranea Britannica, Evening Standard (2015). Revenue figures are rough estimates for discussion.